Journalism and Technology, Winter 2011

Syllabus v1, December 3, 2010

Instructors

Larry Birnbaum	**Jeremy Gilbert**	**Kristian J. Hammond**
birnbaum@eecs.northwestern.edu	jgilbert@northwestern.edu	hammond@eecs.northwestern.edu
847-491-3640	847-467-0874	847-467-1012
Ford 3.325	MTC 4-125	Ford 3.320

Course description

The future of journalism requires new skills and new uses of technology. Journalists and computer scientists need to know how to communicate if they are to create the systems and tools to aid in the creation, consumption and distribution of media. This class is a multidisciplinary, cooperative classroom experience that brings together journalism and computer science students to create experimental systems and tools for media. Through group project work and presentations to their peers, industry experts and faculty, you will learn to manage projects and gain exposure to other disciplines.

Learning objectives

1. *Innovation:* To explore uncharted areas of the intersection between journalism and technology.
2. *Cooperation:* To build collaboration through group work for students of different disciplines.
3. *Presentation:* To learn how to clearly and concisely communicate ideas to an audience and to offer and receive constructive criticism in a public setting.

Course outline

During the quarter, teams will develop a working system aimed at the generation, presentation and deployment of news and information. The goal is to fuse technology and journalism. Doing more than simply implementing or improving upon what we already know, but creating new ways to tell stories and share information.
Each group will learn about project definition, data collection, technology selection, implementation, and project management.

The goal of each team will be the development of a complete application on the Web or in conjunction with a large-scale database system. While the work of the course will be to build systems, the ultimate point is the development of a set of skills that will allow you to do problem solving in the area of information access and management as well as a better understanding of the issues of journalism and media. All students will work in teams with responsibility shared among members. In particular, you will work in cross-functional teams made up of both technologists and journalists. Our expectation is that all team members will participate in the framing, architecture and implementation of projects.

Equipment

Students are not required to use particular software or equipment but are encouraged to determine what they will while outlining their project. It is expected that most of the software and tools used during the quarter will either be open source or tools you are already using.

Prerequisites

Class time will not be spent teaching particularly software or programming languages. Should you need assistance the course instructors can provide advice outside of class.

Academic integrity

Students are responsible for knowing and following Medill's and McCormick's policies concerning academic integrity.

- Medill: http://bit.ly/hUQWlo
- McComick: http://bit.ly/g9vJyV

No breaches of academic integrity will be tolerated in this class. Cheating, plagiarism or failure to attribute material properly may result in failing this class.

Disability

Any student with a verified disability requiring special accommodations should speak to the course instructor and to the Office of Services for Students with Disabilities (847-467-5530) as early as possible in the quarter, preferably within the first **two weeks** of the course. All discussions will remain confidential.

Class Behavior

During class discussions, and when otherwise noted, you should not have your laptops open. Texting, IM, e-mail, cell phone usage should be done during class breaks. You will be asked to leave the classroom if you use them during course instruction.

Attendance

Attendance is required at all class meetings. If a student is unable to attend class, he/she must notify instructor by e-mail or phone at least 2 hours before class. If a student misses class he/she is responsible for material and feedback covered in class.

Publishing About This Class

This class encourages you to explore media and technology. Students are encouraged to think and share things they learn in class. However, to ensure healthy, candid discussions and questions students prohibited from quoting other students without express permission.

Grading

Students will be graded on progress toward the goal of a complete system. There will be midterm and final demonstrations of your work plus a final write-up of the system.

Your deliverables will include:

Weekly

- Weekly report — one per team, about one page not including diagrams. Include sections on each of the following:
  - What were your team's deliverables for this week
  - What was accomplished
  - What was learned
  - What stumbling blocks were encountered
  - What are your next set of tasks
- Presentation
  - A verbal account of your report
- Demonstration
  - Show your working product

Midterm

- Peer Evaluation
  - Evaluate each teammate
  - Your own goals for the rest of the quarter
  - Team goals for the rest of the quarter

Final

- A paper describing the project, the functionality it provides, the audience it addresses and the potential market it provides.
- Peer evaluation outlining the work done and the roles of each of the team members.
- A documented code base that supports your implementation.
- A final public presentation to the faculty and invited guests (clients, investors, potential buyers).

Engagement
Students are expected to attend and participate in all classes. Students will be graded on a combination of attendance and participation.

Week	Deliverable	Points
2	Team Report & Presentation: Project Outline	10
3	Team Report & Presentation	10
4	Team Report & Presentation	10
5	Team Report & Presentation	10
5	Midterm Peer Evaluation	15
6	Team Report & Presentation	10
7	Team Report & Presentation	10
8	Team Report & Presentation	10
9	Final Presentation	30
9	Final Report	30
9	Peer Evaluation	20
9	Code base	15
	Engagement	20
	Total	**200**

Teaching Method
The class meets twice a week. During Tuesday classes will be used for class discussion and will include lab time for teams to work with each other and get feedback from faculty members and other students.

The class will be following an Agile process, each week every team will describe its current status with regard to development and we will define the work for the coming week.

Thursday classes will be weekly presentations and demos. Each week students are required to explain what they did, why they did and how it fulfills the needs of their audience. While PowerPoint is not required, structured presentations are. Over the course of the quarter all team members must present.

Projects
We have some project ideas that will be starting points for the actual systems that you will develop over the quarter. These are starting points and we will negotiate details during the first session of class. If you have other things that you would like to work on, please feel free to bring them to class,